

James Chambers

CLOUD DEVOPS ENGINEER

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UK national · Open to remote or hybrid roles in the North East

3M+

users on the platform

33%

lower monthly cloud spend

3 wks → 20 min

application deployment

1 → 5

platform engineers, 3 countries

Cloud DevOps engineer on Azure and AWS, running my own Linux servers since 2010. At a 3M-user education platform I brought a hand-managed estate under pipelines and monitoring, and now run the platform behind its generative-AI product.

— EXPERIENCE

Cloud DevOps Engineer / Kortext

CONTRACT · REMOTE · AUG 2024 – PRESENT

Sole infrastructure engineer on arrival. Now own all cloud infrastructure across Azure and AWS for a platform serving 3M+ users across a portfolio of around ten products, plus the platform team I built from a standing start to five engineers in three countries.

- **Infrastructure as code.** Introduced the first CI/CD pipelines and brought a hand-managed estate under Terraform and Terragrunt, with Helm, Helmfile and ArgoCD driving GitOps delivery. A three-week manual deployment now runs as a single 20-minute pipeline.
- **Production Kubernetes.** 150+ microservices on nine clusters, four AKS and five EKS, across UK, North America and Australia regions and six environments from dev through to separate UK and North America production. Namespace isolation for multi-tenant client workloads, KEDA event-driven autoscaling and Goldilocks pod right-sizing.
- **Cloud cost.** Cut monthly cloud spend by 33%: tagging and Power BI visibility, right-sizing on Datadog and Goldilocks data, orphaned infrastructure decommissioned, and autoscaling on an estate that had none. Reservations last, once everything had been sized.
- **Observability and on-call.** Built out the monitoring and incident-response function: Datadog APM and synthetics, Azure Log Analytics, Application Insights and PagerDuty. Designed the first on-call rotation, weekly with one engineer out of hours, and still own it. Thresholds tuned against the first month of alert data, and synthetics catch problems before alerts fire.
- **AI incident investigation agent.** A containerised, Claude-based agent that triggers on PagerDuty incidents and posts ranked, evidenced hypotheses back within about five minutes, the top-ranked one correct around 75% of the time. Read-only throughout, and hosted outside the Kubernetes estate so it works when Kubernetes is what failed.
- **AWS to Azure migration.** Migrating acquired Java and MySQL applications from AWS to Azure, cutting each client over with roughly 30 seconds of write downtime using binlog replication and a GTID-verified cutover. Compute cost down 20%, database cost down 35%.
- **Production AI platform.** Application Gateway ingress, Application Insights across six environments, and load testing. (R&D wrote the retrieval and agent layers; mine is the platform underneath.)

Cloud Platform Engineer / UK Government, Core Defra

FULL TIME · REMOTE · FEB 2023 – AUG 2024

- **Managed firewall rollout.** Delivered the network changes for a new managed firewall service across several hundred hub-and-spoke networks, where one wrong route-table entry takes a service off the network.
- **Legacy migration and TLS.** Migrated legacy IIS applications from on-premises into Azure with pipelines that deployed IIS on Windows VMs, and added TLS to applications that had only ever served port 80.
- **Infrastructure build.** Built Azure infrastructure with Bicep and Microsoft's Azure Verified Modules across several hundred VMs and UK-wide database clusters, alongside on-premises domain controllers and hybrid identity.

— EARLIER

Police Constable / Northumbria Police

MAY 2018 – FEB 2023 · VOLUNTEER SPECIAL CONSTABLE TO OCT 2025

Owned the digital and financial evidence strands on a CID caseload: communications data, CCTV retention windows, payment and IP trails, RIPA/DPA applications, and forensics equipment as a digital-trained officer. It came to me because I was the most technical person on the team. Four years on frontline response before that, first on scene at grade 1 emergencies.

Freelance Web Developer — full-stack and infrastructure / Self-employed

JUN 2010 – MAY 2018 · RETAINED CLIENT BOOK, ALONGSIDE OTHER ROLES

Designed, built and ran all client infrastructure on bare metal and DigitalOcean: provisioning, databases, DNS, deployment and backups, where a site down meant client revenue down. Ran the full commercial cycle solo, 16 months of it entirely remote.

TOOLKIT

DELIVERY & IAC

Terraform · Terragrunt · Bicep · Helm · Helmfile · ArgoCD · Azure DevOps · GitHub Actions

CLOUD

Azure · AWS · AKS · EKS · VM Scale Sets · Front Door · Application Gateway and AGIC · Container Apps · Azure Virtual Desktop

OPERATIONS

Datadog APM and synthetics · Log Analytics · Application Insights · PagerDuty · on-call design · incident response · KEDA · Goldilocks · FinOps

NETWORK & SECURITY

Hub and spoke · managed firewall · WAF · private endpoints · PIM · RBAC · TLS automation

DATA

MySQL and PostgreSQL Flexible Server · RDS · binlog replication · GTID cutover

SCRIPTING

Bash · PowerShell · Python

CERTIFICATIONS

AZ-104 2023

Azure Administrator Associate

ITIL 4 2024

Foundation

SC-900 · MS-900 · AZ-900 2023

Security, Microsoft 365 and Azure fundamentals

CLEARANCE

Held Defra-sponsored Security Check (SC) clearance, 2023 to 2024. Now lapsed.

EDUCATION

BA (Hons) Business Management, 2:1

University of East Anglia, 2013

HOW I THINK

Cost. Visibility, right-sizing, scaling, then reservations, in that order. Reservations first commits you to whatever was already oversized.

Incidents. The on-call engineer's first fifteen minutes are dead time. I built an agent to fill them.

Ingress. Fewer ways in. One Layer 7 entry point, where TLS terminates and the WAF sits.